

long tail raised
when threatened



Frilled lizard

Chlamydosaurus kingii

This iconic member of the agamid or “dragon” family—which also includes Australia’s moloch or thorny devil—is famous for its remarkable self-defense display. When threatened, the frilled lizard erects and flutters its highly colored throat-and-neck ruff of elastic skin, using muscles attached to its jaws, tongue, and the rods of cartilage that support the frill. It opens its large mouth wide to show the pale inner lining, raises and flicks its tail or swipes it against the ground, and hisses loudly. The lizard may also stand almost erect on its hindlegs, or hop from one leg to the other, while waving its front limbs to scare off predators, such as snakes, lizards, eagles, feral cats, and quolls (catlike marsupials).

Designed to startle

The sudden, intimidating threat display startles many of the lizard’s enemies into pausing. This gives it time to run away, usually up a nearby trunk—trees are its main home and hunting place—or among rocks. At these times, the umbrellalike frill lies furled almost flat over the upper back and shoulders.

◁ THREAT DISPLAY

When in danger, the lizard may display its frilled neck and simply stand its ground, or it may lunge at the adversary in mock attack, snapping its jaws, and scratching with its claws.

The frilled lizard uses its frill-erecting display for other reasons as well as defense: males repel intruders from their territory with it, and at breeding time it helps to deter rival males. Both sexes display to impress potential mates. The neck frill also plays an important role in controlling body temperature, acting at times as a sunshade, absorber of the sun’s warmth, or radiator of excess body heat.

Temperature dependence

Breeding usually occurs from September to November, as the rains promise an abundance of food, especially insects such as ants, termites, cicadas, and caterpillars. After mating, the female digs a nest hole in loose soil and lays 5–20 soft-shelled eggs, then leaves—there is no maternal care. The eggs take around 10 weeks to hatch. The sex of the young is partially dependent on temperature. Both sexes develop from eggs incubated at temperatures of 84–95°F (29–35°C), but at temperatures above and below this range, the young produced are exclusively female. When the babies dig their way out of the nest, they are capable of putting on a full-frontal frill display straight away.

▷ ARBOREAL LIFESTYLE

A frilled lizard spends up to 90 percent of its time on trees. When lying still, or resting, it is very well camouflaged as bark. The lizard can be speedy and agile when it is in search of ants and bugs.



↔ 28–36 in (71–91 cm)
 ⚖ 18–28 oz (510–794 g)
 ⊗ Common
 🕷 Insects, spiders, amphibians
 🏠



S. New Guinea,
N. Australia